

Gandhi's Decision

It is 1893. Gandhi rides on a train in South Africa. The train travels into the night. Gandhi sits in first class. The train stops. A White man gets on the train. He sees Gandhi. The White man says, "Get out of here."

Gandhi is Indian. In South Africa, Indian people cannot ride in first class. Gandhi will not leave his seat. The police throw Gandhi off the train. Gandhi spends a long, cold night in the train station. This night changes Gandhi's life.

Fact: Gandhi is 24 years old.

Gandhi sits in the train station. He thinks about his future. He needs to make a decision. Should he fight for Indians' rights in South Africa? Or should he return home to India? He decides to fight for Indians' rights.

Fact: Gandhi stays in South Africa for 21 years.

Early Years

Gandhi was born in India in 1869. He is a shy, quiet child. Gandhi starts school at age seven. He works hard. He is an average student. Gandhi does not like sports. He likes to take long walks by himself.

Fact: Gandhi's full name at birth is Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi.

Gandhi's family are Hindus. In the 1800s, most Hindus marry at a young age. Gandhi's parents choose his wife. Her name is Kasturba. Gandhi and Kasturba marry in 1882. They are both 13 years old. Their first child is born in 1886.

Fact: Gandhi and Kasturba are married for 62 years.

Gandhi wants to study law in England. Gandhi's mother does not want him to go. Gandhi makes three promises. He will not eat meat or drink alcohol. And he will not have sex in England. Gandhi sails to India at age 19.

Fact: Gandhi's wife and son stay in India.

Life in South Africa

Gandhi gets his law degree in 1891. He sails home to India. There are not many jobs for lawyers. Gandhi cannot find good work in India. He finds work in South Africa. He also finds racism in South Africa.

Fact: Gandhi works as a lawyer in South Africa.

White people rule South Africa. They pass racist laws. Indian people cannot own property. Indian people

cannot stay in hotels for White people. Indian people pay higher taxes than White people. Indian people do not have equal rights in South Africa.

Fact: Gandhi forms the Natal Indian Congress in 1894.

Gandhi's Beliefs

Gandhi wants to make life better for Indians. He wants to learn how to fight racism. He reads holy books. He learns from the different religions. Gandhi learns that peaceful ways can bring change.

Fact: Gandhi reads the Bible, the Koran, and other holy books.

Many leaders use violence to make change. Gandhi is different. He believes in non-violence and truth. Gandhi calls these two beliefs satyagraha. This word means truth-force. Gandhi believes that truth and non-violence are strong forces. These forces can lead to change.

Fact: Satyagraha is pronounced sat-ya-gra-ha.

Gandhi believes a simple life leads to harmony. Gandhi changes his life. He gives up his wealth. He gives up his home. He gives up his fine clothes. Gandhi begins to live a simple life.

Gandhi starts an ashram in 1904. The ashram is a community of people who live together. People live and work together on a farm. People build a simple life on the farm. They grow their own food. They make their own furniture.

Gandhi leads many protests in South Africa. He protests racist laws. He gets Indians to go on strike. He wins the Indians more rights. Gandhi is beaten for being a leader. Gandhi is put in prison for being a leader.

Fact: In 1914, South Africa's new laws give Indians basic rights.

Life in India

In 1915, Gandhi returns to India. He is a hero. He is famous for his work in South Africa. Gandhi travels around India for a year. He learns about India's problems. He sees poverty and hunger. Gandhi wants to see change in India.

Fact: People give Gandhi the name Mahatma, which means great soul.

Hindus are born into different castes or social groups. The lowest caste is called the untouchables. They do not have any rights. Gandhi believes India's caste system is a problem. Gandhi tells Indians to treat the untouchables as equals.

Fact: Gandhi gives the untouchables a new name: Harijan. This means "The Children of God."

Gandhi's Protests

At that time, the British control India. The British treat Indians like second-class citizens. Gandhi wants to free India from the British. Gandhi believes Indians must depend upon themselves. Indians must solve the problems of India. Gandhi starts to protest British control.

Fact: Gandhi becomes a leader of the Indian National Congress in 1919.

Gandhi stops buying British goods. He tells Indians to stop buying British clothes. Gandhi leads the way. He spins 200 metres of thread every day. In the 1920s, Indians learn to spin and weave. The spinning wheel becomes a symbol of protest.

Fact: The Indians weave thread on a handloom to make cloth.

Gandhi protests British laws. The Salt Acts do not allow Indians to gather and sell salt. Gandhi leads a 24-day march to the sea. Gandhi reaches the sea. He picks up a few grains of salt. This simple act is a symbol of protest.

Gandhi leads a big protest against the British in 1942. The British send Gandhi and Kasturba to prison. Kasturba gets sick and dies in Gandhi's arms. A part of Gandhi dies with her. Gandhi leaves prison in 1944. He keeps working for India's freedom.

Fact: Gandhi spends a total of 2,338 days of his life in jail.

In 1947, India gains freedom from British rule. Gandhi wants one India. This does not happen. Many Hindus and Muslims do not want to live together. India splits into two countries. This split makes many people angry. An angry Hindu man kills Gandhi.

Fact: Gandhi is shot on January 30, 1948.

Gandhi's Flame

Gandhi stood for truth. Gandhi stood for justice. Gandhi stood for non-violence. Gandhi's body is burned on a fire. The fire burned out long ago. But Gandhi's flame still warms the world. Gandhi made the world a better place.